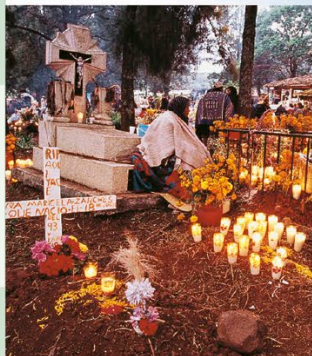




Mexico

ONCE HOME TO THE GREAT Aztec and Mayan civilizations and then the focus of Spanish conquistadors who came in search of wealth, Mexico today reflects its colorful past through its culture and architecture. The majority of Mexicans is mestizo (mixed race), of Spanish and native Indian descent. Mexico City, site of the ancient Aztec capital, is today one of the largest cities in the world, with a population of around 21 million. Despite oil and natural gas reserves, and a plentiful supply of labor, large numbers of Mexicans are still poor, especially in the rural areas and the urban slums.

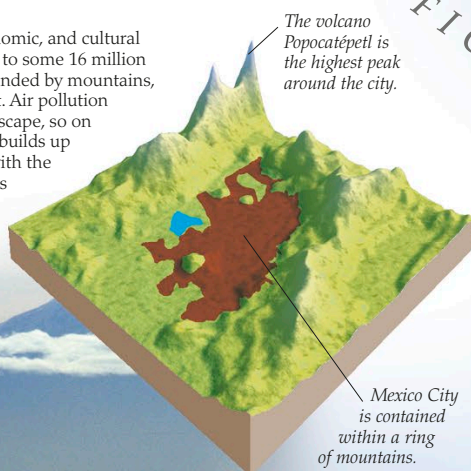
ALONG THE BORDER
In 1994, Mexico signed the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA), which effectively bound its economy to that of the US. A large industrial area has developed along the Mexican border with the US.



DAY OF THE DEAD
One of the biggest festivals in Mexico is the Day of the Dead. It is believed that once a year the souls of the dead can come back and visit their loved ones. In celebration of this, special food is prepared to welcome the souls, and offerings of flowers, candles, and incense are made at the gravesides.

LIFE IN THE CITY

Mexico City is the political, economic, and cultural hub of the country, and is home to some 16 million people. Its site, in a basin surrounded by mountains, means that expansion is difficult. Air pollution from factories and cars cannot escape, so on most days a thick layer of smog builds up over the city. Attempts to deal with the pollution, including banning cars from some parts, have had limited success.



The volcano Popocatepetl is the highest peak around the city.

Mexico City is contained within a ring of mountains.

WORKING ON THE LAND

Agriculture employs 6.5 million people – about one-eighth of Mexico's work force. However, only 12 percent of the land is suitable for farming because it is so mountainous and dry. The peasant communities of the south rely on farming for their food, while communities in the north are more industrialized. Here, the agave plant is being harvested near the town of Tequila.

